PRODUCT MANAGEMENT PORTFOLIO · CASE STUDY

# RewardTrust

Building the Missing Transparency Layer for Indian UPI Rewards


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AUDIENCE

Hiring Managers at CRED, PhonePe, Razorpay, Jupiter, Fi, Groww, Zerodha, Swiggy, Amazon

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## 01 — EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

# Why This Project Matters

*Indian UPI has a paradox at its core. The same users who can name the cashback rate of every major credit card — who debate reward optimization strategies on Reddit threads with 2,000 upvotes — also describe their reward experiences as "random," "confusing," and "not worth trusting."*

India has produced the most reward-literate payment users in the world. It has also produced the most reward-distrustful. RewardTrust is the product built for this paradox. It is a reward transparency platform for Indian UPI users — not a payment app, not a cashback provider, but the neutral information layer that sits between reward systems that already exist and the users who cannot navigate them.

It answers four questions that no existing product answers reliably:

- Will I get a reward if I pay with this app or card?
- How much will I get on this specific transaction?
- When will I get it and what is its current status?
- And when a reward doesn't arrive — why didn't I get it?

> **"RewardTrust tells you what you'll earn before you pay, and explains exactly why after — so rewards finally build the trust they were designed to build."**

**~95%**
First-time transactors who never discovered their reward in 30 days

**>60%**
UPI transactions that generate a backend reward users never see

**~16 days**
Average time from transaction to reward discovery

The problem is not that rewards are too small. Funnel analysis of a leading RuPay credit card UPI product revealed that users who experienced the complete reward loop returned at **over 80% rates** — proving the product works for those who find it. The rewards exist. The trust-building is not happening. RewardTrust closes this gap.

Existing solutions fail because they misread the diagnosis. Comparison tools (BankBazaar, Paisabazaar) address the wrong question — users aren't failing to compare, they're failing to trust. Smart payment advisors (Jupiter, Fi) over-promise. Only a trust layer — neutral, accurate, explanatory — addresses the actual disease rather than the most visible symptom.

> **RewardTrust's neutrality is its moat.** Payment companies cannot credibly be a neutral trust layer for their own rewards. This structural advantage cannot be replicated by any incumbent.

02 — PROBLEM DISCOVERY

# Starting With Data, Not Assumptions

This project began with funnel analysis — four funnels from a leading RuPay credit card UPI product, covering the complete reward lifecycle from card activation to repeat transactions. The data produced findings that challenged initial assumptions about what the reward problem actually was.

## What the Funnels Revealed

### FUNNEL 1 — CARD ACTIVATION TO REPEAT TRANSACTION (30 DAYS)

Of ~10,000 cardholders, roughly **65%** completed a first transaction within 30 days. Of those, nearly all generated a reward in the backend within approximately 2 hours. Of those reward recipients, **~83% returned for a second transaction**. Overall end-to-end conversion: ~53%.

### FUNNEL 2 — TRANSACTION TO REWARD REVEAL (7 DAYS)

~280,000 UPI transaction loads. Less than 1% of users revealed a reward surprise (~0.3% conversion). Of those revealers, ~85% received a confirmed reward. Time from transaction to reward discovery: ~3 days.

### FUNNEL 3 — NON-CREDITED REWARD STATE (30 DAYS)

~280,000 UPI loads. Over **60%** generated a *reward_won_backend* event where the reward was NOT credited to the user. Only ~11% of those users ever revealed/claimed the reward. Time from reward generation to discovery: **~16 days**.

### FUNNEL 4 — NEW USER REWARD UNDERSTANDING (30 DAYS)

The most diagnostic funnel. Same cohort of cardholders as Funnel 1. Of first transactors, only **~5%** actively engaged with the reward surprise. Those users returned at **~83%** for a second transaction.

> **The finding that reframed the entire analysis:** The second-transaction rate for passive reward recipients and active reward revealers was statistically identical (both ~83%). This raised a harder question: does the reveal cause retention, or are high-intent users simply both revealing AND retaining? This ambiguity is the most important unresolved question in the product strategy.

## Quantifying the Problem at Market Scale

| Metric | Finding | Source |
|---|---|---|
| Reward-linked transactions as % of total digital payments (India, H1 2024) | ~11% — 89% of payments generate no reward engagement | Digital Payments Loyalty Report, 2025 |
| Growth in reward-linked transactions (H1 2024 → H1 2025) | 10.86% → 17.06% — rising fast, still a minority | Digital Payments Loyalty Report, 2025 |
| Consumers who admit forgetting to redeem earned rewards | ~40% globally; higher in India's fragmented multi-app environment | Deloitte Consumer Loyalty Survey, 2024 |
| Repeat purchase intent: clear reward vs. no reward experience | 60–80% higher intent when reward is clearly experienced | Deloitte Consumer Loyalty Survey, 2024 |
| UPI users who say rewards influence spending behavior | 74.2% | NPCI-linked market research, 2025 |
| Annual per-user reward value left uncaptured | ₹2,000 – ₹8,000 | Estimated from published UPI cashback rates × average spend |
| First transactors who never discovered their reward (30 days) | ~95% | Internal product funnel analysis |
| Unclaimed reward events per month (one product alone) | 150,000+ | Internal product funnel analysis |

## User Research: What Communities Were Saying

Beyond the quantitative data, user sentiment was synthesized across r/IndiaFinance, r/CreditCardsIndia, app store reviews, and LinkedIn fintech commentary. The volume of reward complaints across these communities is significant, but more important is their nature: users are not complaining about small rewards. They are complaining about unpredictability, opacity, and broken promises.

**12 recurring frustration themes, ranked by composite impact (frequency × severity):**

| Rank | Frustration | Composite Score |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Scratchcards give paise not rupees | 84 |
| 2 | Can't see eligibility before paying | **89** |
| 3 | Found a better offer after paying | 80 |
| 4 | Cashback takes 7–10 days to credit | 73 |
| 5 | CRED coins have opaque, shifting value | 78 |
| 6 | Different users get different offer amounts | 78 |
| 7 | Multi-condition eligibility is impossible to satisfy | 74 |
| 8 | Reward program changed without notice | 74 |
| 9 | Reward shown but never appears in balance | 70 |
| 10 | Flash sale rewards always sold out | 62 |
| 11 | Notification spam with no useful offer content | 62 |
| 12 | Reward earned but can't find where it went | 62 |

Notice that the top frustration by severity (#2 — can't see eligibility before paying) is fundamentally a visibility and trust problem, not a value problem.

## The Four Trust Gaps

| Gap | Name | Description |
|---|---|---|
| **Gap 1** | Anticipation | Users don't know before they pay whether a reward is possible. The decision moment — which app to use — happens with zero reward information available. Rewards cannot influence behavior they cannot be known at. |
| **Gap 2** | Delivery | Users can't see that a reward has been generated after they pay. The backend credits the reward; the user sees an unchanged balance. The implicit product promise fails at the very moment of fulfillment. |
| **Gap 3** | Status | When rewards are delayed (industry average: 2–10 days), users have no way to know whether their reward is pending, failed, or simply not earned. Silence is interpreted as failure. |
| **Gap 4** | Explanation | When a reward isn't received, users get no explanation. They cannot distinguish "transaction was ineligible" from "system failure" from "reward still processing." Without explanation, every missed reward is a perceived broken promise. |

03 — USER PERSONAS

# Four Behavioral Archetypes

Four personas derived from behavioral research synthesis across Indian UPI communities, funnel analysis data, and market segmentation. Each persona represents a distinct behavioral archetype — not a demographic segment.

P1

### Priya Sharma — "The Habitual Payer"

Software Engineer, 28, Bangalore · ₹85,000/month · PhonePe user since 2018

**GOALS**

- Not feel stupid for leaving obvious money behind
- Understand the simplest possible improvement to her payment behavior
- Not add complexity she can't sustain

**PAIN POINTS**

- Not feeling that rewards exist at all — the product promise has normalized to zero
- Every time she tries to understand the rewards landscape, she ends up confused
- Has approximately ₹3,500 in annual uncaptured reward value she doesn't know exists

> *"I know I'm probably missing out on cashback but every time I try to figure it out I end up confused and just go back to PhonePe."*

P2

## Rahul Mehta — "The Context-Switcher"

Product Manager, 33, Mumbai · ₹1,80,000/month · Three credit cards, used intentionally

**GOALS**

- Confidence that every payment decision is optimal
- Comprehensive understanding without added complexity
- Answers at the decision moment, not from 15 minutes of pre-payment research

**PAIN POINTS**

- The incompleteness of his mental model — he knows gaps exist but can't quantify them
- "Is Kiwi better than Amazon Pay ICICI for this merchant?" requires 15 minutes of T&C research
- His system is good enough that improving it feels like more work than it's worth

> *"I have a decent system but I know there are gaps. I'd pay for a tool that just tells me 'for Swiggy, your best card is X, here's why' without me having to figure it out."*

P3

## Divya Iyer — "The Offer-Seeker" ⭐ MVP Primary

Content Creator, 25, Delhi · ₹45,000–₹75,000/month · Active on personal finance Twitter/YouTube

**GOALS**

- Never experience reward regret — discovering a better offer after paying
- Save the 3–5 minutes per week spent checking fragmented offer sections
- Feel like the system is working for her, not against her

**PAIN POINTS**

- The effort-to-outcome ratio — she does the work but the system defeats her anyway
- Offers that require pre-activation she wasn't aware of
- Growing cynicism that the system is deliberately designed to make offers hard to find

> *"I check PhonePe and GPay before every Swiggy order but I always feel like there's an offer somewhere I'm missing. I want one place to see everything."*

P4

### Arjun Nair — "The Power Optimizer" ⭐ MVP

Data Analyst, 31, Pune · ₹2,10,000/month · Six apps, three credit cards, personal reward tracking spreadsheet

**GOALS**

- Replace his manual spreadsheet with something that maintains itself
- Reduce the 2+ hours per month updating his system when rates change
- Confirmation that his routing is actually optimal, not just approximately optimal

**PAIN POINTS**

- Information currency — his system is only as good as his most recent update
- Rate changes are announced with no fanfare and take weeks to find
- No way to verify that his current routing is actually optimal vs. "approximately optimal"

> *"I know what I'm doing but keeping the information current is a part-time job. If someone built a good tool for this I'd switch to it immediately."*

## Persona Priority Matrix

| Persona | Segment Size | Acquisition Ease | LTV | MVP Priority |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Priya — Habitual Payer | ~55% of UPI users | Low | Medium | PHASE 2 |
| Rahul — Context-Switcher | ~25% of UPI users | Medium | High | PHASE 1 ★ |
| Divya — Offer-Seeker | ~15% of UPI users | High | Very High | MVP ★ |
| Arjun — Power Optimizer | ~5% of UPI users | Very High | Medium | MVP ★ |

04 — JOBS TO BE DONE

# What Users Are Actually Hiring For

Jobs are defined at three levels: functional (what needs to be accomplished), emotional (how the user wants to feel), and social (how they want to be perceived). The emotional and social jobs are often the primary purchase and retention drivers — and the most underserved by existing products.

JTBD 1 · PRIMARY MVP

### The Pre-Decision Job

FUNCTIONAL

When I am about to make a payment and I have more than one option available, I want to know which option will earn me the most reward for this specific transaction at this specific merchant, so I can make the economically optimal choice without interrupting my payment flow.

EMOTIONAL

I want to feel confident that I am not leaving money behind — that I made an informed decision rather than a lazy default one.

SOCIAL

I want to be the person who has figured out how to earn money from things I'm already buying, not the person who pays full price while everyone else earns cashback.

> The key insight: The job is not "find the best reward." It is **"stop worrying about what I'm missing."** The emotional job — relief from reward anxiety — is the primary driver.

### JTBD 2 The Post-Transaction Verification Job

**FUNCTIONAL**

After completing a payment, I want to immediately know whether I earned a reward, how much it is, and when it will credit, so I can close the reward loop and move on — or escalate if something went wrong.

**EMOTIONAL**

I want to feel that the product kept its promise. The implicit contract — "use this, earn rewards" — should be confirmed at completion, not left ambiguous for days.

### JTBD 3 The Explanation Job

**FUNCTIONAL**

When I do not receive a reward I expected, I want a specific, accurate explanation of why, so I can update my mental model and make a better decision next time — and so I know whether the product failed me or the transaction was genuinely ineligible.

**DESIGN IMPLICATION**

"The transaction was ineligible because it was a NEFT transfer, not a UPI payment" has enormous value — not just as information, but as cognitive relief. It converts a broken promise into a learnable rule. This is the highest trust-building moment in the product, and it's currently absent from every major UPI payment app.

05 — OPPORTUNITY ANALYSIS

# The Market Gap Is Not What It Appears to Be

The surface-level market gap in Indian UPI rewards is obvious: there's no pre-transaction reward comparison tool. Users ask "which app gives better cashback for Swiggy?" thousands of times across fintech communities every week, and no product answers it directly. A PM who stops here builds a comparison tool — and misses the actual opportunity.

The deeper market gap is this: there is no neutral, trustworthy source of information about how Indian UPI rewards actually work. Not what they could hypothetically earn (marketing), not what they sometimes earn (experience), but what they will reliably earn on a specific transaction with specific conditions, with a clear explanation when the outcome doesn't match the expectation.

## Why Comparison Tools Are Insufficient

A comparison tool solves a symptom. The symptom is "I don't know which app gives better cashback." The disease is "I don't trust that any of these apps will reliably reward me as promised." These require different products.

Concretely: if the problem were simply comparison difficulty, Amazon Pay's transparent "5% on Amazon, 1% everywhere else" would have captured the market. It hasn't — because Amazon Pay's transparency within its own ecosystem doesn't solve the multi-app, cross-merchant comparison problem. And even if a perfect comparison tool existed, it wouldn't address Gaps 2, 3, and 4 from the problem diagnosis: delivery, status, and explanation. A user who chooses the optimal payment method based on a comparison tool, then can't verify whether the reward arrived, is still experiencing 75% of the trust problem.

## Why RewardTrust Is Positioned as a Trust Layer

**Structural Conflict of Interest:** A neutral trust layer must rank all payment products objectively — including ranking the ranking product's own services below competitors when those competitors offer better rewards. PhonePe cannot credibly do this. GPay cannot credibly do this. CRED cannot credibly do this. Only a product with no financial stake in any specific payment outcome can credibly claim neutrality.

**Trust Compounds Over Time:** A trust layer that has maintained 99% data accuracy for two years, never adjusted rankings for commercial relationships, and correctly explained 50,000 reward failures has earned something that cannot be replicated by a new entrant or copied by an incumbent. The track record is the product.

**B2B Model Unlocked:** When RewardTrust is known as the neutral trust infrastructure for Indian payment rewards, payment companies have a business reason to license RewardTrust's data and API rather than build their own. They want their rewards to be trusted. A trusted third-party certification serves their interests.

# Vision, North Star & Core Value Proposition

## Three-Year Vision

RewardTrust becomes the standard trust infrastructure for Indian payment rewards — the entity whose data and ratings determine whether a payment product's rewards are perceived as trustworthy by the market. When a bank launches a new credit card with rewards, they submit their rate data to RewardTrust for verification. When a consumer wants to know if a reward program is reliable, they check RewardTrust's track record score.

> This is not an app at scale. It is the **Trustpilot for Indian payment rewards** — a trust infrastructure company whose most visible face is a consumer product.

## North Star Metric

**Reward Discovery Rate (RDR):** The percentage of eligible transactions made by active RewardTrust users in which the user correctly identified the optimal payment method before transacting.

This is the right North Star for three reasons: it measures actual behavioral change (not just that users visited the product), it is honest about the product's purpose (financial value delivered, not engagement), and it creates a direct economic story — every point increase in RDR means users are leaving less money on the table.

**Target:** 35% of logged transactions use the recommended payment method (vs. ~12% estimated baseline from organic behavior).

## Core Value Proposition

RewardTrust delivers three things simultaneously that no other product delivers:

| # | Promise | What It Means |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Specificity before the decision** | Not "you might earn something" but "you will earn exactly ₹22 with this card on this transaction at this merchant, subject to these conditions." |
| 2 | **Honesty when the decision has passed** | Not "your reward is processing" (silence) but "this transaction was not eligible because [specific reason], and here is what you could have earned instead." |
| 3 | **Neutrality that makes both credible** | The comparison is trustworthy because it has no commercial stake in the answer. The explanation is trustworthy because it applies the same standard to all products. |

## Product Philosophy

**Honesty over optimization.** RewardTrust never shows users what they want to hear — it shows what is accurate. If the best reward for a transaction is ₹2, it says ₹2. If rate data is potentially stale, it says so. Inflating expectations would destroy the trust the product is built to create faster than any competitor could.

**Clarity over completeness.** A user deciding which app to use has approximately 45 seconds. A result that shows 8 options with varying conditions across different time windows serves completeness but fails clarity. The product must make a recommendation, not present a research brief.

**Proximity to the decision moment.** Every feature is evaluated by how close it gets the relevant information to the moment the user needs it. A monthly reward summary delivered three weeks after the decisions have been made has a fraction of the behavioral value of pre-transaction information delivered within 45 seconds.

07 — MVP DEFINITION

# The Prioritization Framework

The MVP was scoped by answering one question: what is the minimum product that validates the most important hypothesis while being genuinely useful to real users? The most important hypothesis is: *users presented with accurate pre-transaction reward information will make measurably different payment decisions.*

## What Was Included

### MERCHANT REWARD LOOKUP (CORE EXPERIENCE)

- Search with 20 quick-select high-volume merchants
- Amount entry with "UPI payment" vs "Card payment" toggle
- Ranked results displaying specific rupee amounts (not percentages)
- Top recommendation highlighted with a single-sentence reason
- All eligibility conditions displayed inline — not hidden, not behind a click
- Results within 2 seconds; no account required

### STATIC REWARD RATE DATABASE V1

- 20 merchants × 8 payment methods = 160 curated rate entries
- Manually maintained from official T&C sources
- Structured from day one for Phase 2 API migration
- Every entry includes: rate, conditions, cap, last verified date, source URL, confidence level

## What Was Intentionally Excluded

| Feature | Why Excluded | Phase |
|---|---|---|
| Post-transaction reward verification | Requires user accounts, transaction logging infrastructure, and a reward status data layer that is 2–3× the engineering scope of the MVP. | PHASE 2 |
| Push notifications | Notifications without an established product relationship generate opt-outs. Notifications after 30 days of demonstrated value generate engagement. The sequence matters. | PHASE 2 |
| User accounts and cloud sync | Account creation before first value is a conversion blocker. First useful result within 60 seconds, no account required — this is the correct design for a product whose first job is to prove its value before asking for commitment. | PHASE 2 |
| AI-powered personalization | RewardTrust at MVP has zero user transaction history, zero spending pattern data, and a manually maintained rate database. Personalization is built on data generated by the product being used — it cannot precede that usage. | PHASE 3+ |

## MVP 4-Week Build Plan

| Week | Focus | Key Deliverables |
|---|---|---|
| **Week 1** | Foundation | React app, JSON rate database (160 entries), search + amount entry UI |
| **Week 2** | Core Experience | Ranked results, conditions display, quick-select chips, recommendation highlight, local profile storage |
| **Week 3** | Polish & Trust | Data freshness indicator, suggest-a-merchant, share functionality, mobile-responsive, <2s load time |
| **Week 4** | Launch & Learn | Deploy to Vercel, seed r/IndiaFinance and r/CreditCardsIndia, analytics instrumentation, first 50 user interviews |

# Core Interaction Design

## Flow 1: Pre-Transaction Reward Lookup (Core MVP)

This is the product's primary experience and its raison d'être. Every design decision in this flow was evaluated against one criterion: can a user who is standing in front of a merchant with 45 seconds to decide complete this flow and get a useful answer?

| Step | Experience | Design Rationale |
| --- | --- | --- |
| **Landing** | App opens directly to a search interface — no splash screen, no sign-in wall, no onboarding sequence. Single prominent search field + horizontally scrolling merchant quick-selects (Swiggy, Zomato, Amazon, Flipkart, BigBasket, IRCTC, BookMyShow, Uber, + 12 more). | Opening to the search screen is the product's primary trust signal: "We're not here to collect your data. We're here to tell you what you'll earn." |
| **Amount Entry** | Numeric keypad optimized for mobile. Simple toggle between "UPI payment" and "Card payment" (defaults to UPI). "Compare" button activates when a valid amount is entered. | Toggle exists because reward rates often differ between UPI debit and credit card transactions at the same merchant — collapsing these would produce inaccurate results for ~30% of queries. |
| **Results** | Results ranked by reward amount (highest first). Each result shows: payment method name, specific rupee amount, reward type, conditions (if any), status indicator (condition met ✓ or condition not met ✗). Top result highlighted with green accent border and single-sentence recommendation. | Rupees not percentages: "5% on ₹450" requires calculation that "₹22.50" does not. Usefulness wins over impressiveness. |
| **Trust Layer** | Embedded in every result: inline eligibility conditions section displaying — without requiring a click — every condition the user must satisfy to receive the stated reward. Conditions the user likely does not meet are visually differentiated with a warning indicator. | The most common user complaint was discovering a condition that disqualified them after they'd already decided or paid. Hiding conditions behind a "See full terms" click reproduces exactly this problem. |

### Flow 2: Post-Transaction Reward Verification (Phase 2)

The result screen shows one of three states:

| State | Display | Purpose |
| --- | --- | --- |
| STATE A — EARNED | Reward: ₹22 cashback ✓ Earned · Status: Processing (2–3 business days) · Expected credit: [Date] | Confirms the implicit product promise. Closes the loop. |
| STATE B — NOT ELIGIBLE | Reward: None — not eligible · Reason: [specific plain-language explanation] · What you could have earned: ₹9 with Slice credit card | Converts a broken promise into a learnable rule. Highest trust-building moment in the product. |
| STATE C — PROCESSING | Reward: ₹22 estimated · Status: Processing · Check back in 24 hours for confirmation | Eliminates the "silence is interpreted as failure" problem from Gap 3. |

# Why Data Strategy Is the Moat

RewardTrust's entire value proposition rests on one claim: its reward rate information is accurate, current, and trustworthy. Get this right and every other product feature works. Get it wrong once — a user chooses Amazon Pay ICICI expecting ₹47 cashback and earns ₹0 because the rate changed — and the trust damage is catastrophic and disproportionate. A product built on trust cannot survive a high-profile accuracy failure. The data strategy is therefore not a technical implementation detail. It is the core product investment.

## Rate Taxonomy: Three Types, Three Maintenance Approaches

| Type | Example | Update Frequency | Data Source |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Permanent base rates** | Amazon Pay ICICI 5% on Amazon | Annual (with card T&C changes) | Official bank T&C pages |
| **Promotional rates** | 10% Swiggy cashback this month | Weekly | App offer sections, bank website |
| **Daily deals** | ₹100 cashback today only | Daily | Not covered in MVP |

## Three-Tier Confidence System

| Confidence Level | Source Quality | Display Treatment |
|---|---|---|
| HIGH | Rate sourced from official bank T&C page with direct URL reference. Verified by a team member within 72 hours. | Displayed without a freshness disclaimer. |
| MEDIUM | Rate sourced from bank website but conditions complex or subject to interpretation. | "Conditions may apply — verify on [App Name] before relying on high-value decisions." |
| LOW | Rate is older than 72 hours (base rates) or 24 hours (promotional rates), or source was a third-party aggregator. | Prominent freshness warning and recommendation to verify independently. |

> **Zero-tolerance accuracy protocol:** Every rate entry includes a *last_verified_date* field checked at display time. Results with stale data display a freshness indicator regardless of whether the rate itself has changed. This is conservative — it may cause unnecessary friction for rates that haven't actually changed. But the alternative (showing potentially stale data without warning) is a trust failure mode that cannot be recovered from at scale.

## How Data Becomes the Moat

**Volume compounds:** 160 entries at MVP becomes 500 at Phase 2, 2,000 at Phase 3. Each entry requires manual verification to meet the accuracy standard. The verification work done cannot be shortcut.

**Track record compounds:** A database with two years of verified accuracy history is categorically more valuable than an identical database launched today — because trust in data accuracy is earned through demonstrated performance, not claimed through marketing.

**Network effects:** As RewardTrust becomes the standard reference for Indian payment reward rates, payment companies have an incentive to proactively keep their rate data current in the RewardTrust database. An incorrect rate in RewardTrust that causes users to choose a competitor is a business problem for that payment company.

10 — SUCCESS METRICS

# Metric Architecture

The metrics framework is designed to answer one question at each layer: is the product actually doing what it was built to do? Consumer fintech products fail at metrics for one of two reasons: they measure engagement when they should measure outcomes, or they measure outcomes that are easily gamed.

## North Star Metric: Reward Discovery Rate (RDR)

**Definition:** Percentage of eligible transactions made by active RewardTrust users in which the user correctly identified the optimal payment method before transacting.

**Target:** 35% of logged transactions use the recommended payment method (vs. estimated ~12% baseline from organic behavior).

## Input Metrics — Leading Indicators

Reviewed weekly. These are the levers the product team can directly pull.

| Metric | Definition | Target | Why It Matters |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| **I1 — Daily Active Lookups** | Unique merchant reward lookups per day | 500/day (Wk 4), 5,000/day (Mo 3) | Primary signal the product is entering the pre-payment routine |
| **I2 — Time to First Result (TTR)** | Median time from app open to first result | ≤ 45 seconds | Determines whether RewardTrust is usable in the 45-second pre-payment window |
| **I3 — Result Quality Score (RQS)** | % of results where data confirmed accurate within 72h | ≥ 95% at all times | One confidently delivered inaccurate result destroys more trust than ten correct low-value results |
| **I4 — Condition Clarity Rate** | % of users who correctly answer "Does this offer apply to you?" after viewing a result | ≥ 80% correct comprehension | Displaying conditions is necessary but not sufficient — they must be understood |
| **I5 — 7-Day Retention** | % of users with ≥ 2 lookups in the 7 days after first use | 40% by Month 2 | Single-use visits create no behavioral change; the habit loop requires repeated proximate use |

## Output Metrics — Lagging Indicators

Reviewed monthly.

| Metric | Definition | Target |
| --- | --- | --- |
| **O1 — Monthly Active Users** | Unique users active per month | 1K (Mo 1), 10K (Mo 3), 50K (Mo 6) |
| **O2 — Reward Optimization Rate** | % of logged transactions using recommended method | 35% (Mo 1), 50% (Mo 3) |
| **O3 — Monthly Reward Value Unlocked** | Est. additional reward value captured vs. pre-RewardTrust baseline | ₹150/user/month additional at Mo 3 |
| **O4 — RewardTrust NPS** | "How much do you trust your payment apps are rewarding you fairly?" vs. control | +20 NPS points vs. control by Mo 3 |
| **O5 — Week-4 Retention** | % of Month-1 users still active in Week 4 | 25% (industry benchmark: 15–20%) |

## Guardrail Metrics

These four metrics cannot be traded off against any other metric. Violating them is a product emergency.

| Guardrail | Threshold | Response |
| --- | --- | --- |
| **G1 — Data Accuracy Rate** | ≥ 95% | Any week below 93% triggers an immediate engineering sprint. |
| **G2 — Misleading result complaint rate** | ≤ 0.5% of lookups | Above 0.5% triggers a data audit. Primary early warning signal for accuracy problems. |
| **G3 — Sponsored result share** | = 0% | Permanently non-negotiable. Any adjustment of rankings for commercial reasons ends the product's reason for existing. |
| **G4 — App load time P95** | ≤ 3 seconds | A product that loads too slowly for the 45-second use case is not a pre-payment tool. |

# Known Risks and Mitigations

### R1 Data Inaccuracy Causing User Harm

Probability: **High** | Impact: **High**

A user follows RewardTrust's recommendation, uses Amazon Pay ICICI expecting ₹47 cashback, and earns ₹0 because the rate changed or a condition wasn't displayed. They don't just leave a 1-star review — they become vocal critics in the exact fintech communities where RewardTrust's reputation matters most.

MITIGATION

- Display data freshness on every result, not on request
- Display all conditions inline, never behind a click
- Add "Was this accurate?" one-tap feedback to every result
- Implement a rate change detection system within the first month
- Caveat high-value results: "Verify on [App] before relying on this for a large purchase"

**Tradeoff accepted:** Some users will see freshness warnings that are technically unnecessary (the rate hasn't actually changed). This creates minor friction in exchange for preventing the catastrophic trust failure of an undisclosed stale rate.

### R2 Payment Company Cease-and-Desist

Probability: **Low** | Impact: **High**

A payment company objects to RewardTrust publishing their reward rates and requests removal, citing intellectual property or brand concerns. Legally, publicly available T&C information is not proprietary. Practically, a legal challenge from a large company could be expensive regardless of merits.

**MITIGATION**

- Display rates as factual data, always cite primary source URL
- Do not use company logos or branded visuals without explicit permission
- Frame the company relationship proactively: RewardTrust makes their rewards more discoverable and more trusted, which serves their interests
- Build personal relationships with product leaders at covered companies before reaching scale
- Move toward API partnerships in Phase 3+ where companies proactively provide rate data

### R3 Commoditization by Incumbents

Probability: **Medium** | Impact: **Medium**

PhonePe, GPay, or Amazon Pay builds a reward comparison feature natively into their app. As the market leader, they can reach 400M+ users overnight. However, an incumbent building a comparison feature for their own app cannot solve the cross-app comparison problem — they have a structural conflict of interest in ranking competitors above themselves. Their "comparison" will be a user-retention feature disguised as a transparency tool.

**MITIGATION**

- Build toward B2B API model where incumbents become partners (licensing RewardTrust's data) rather than competitors
- Establish track record and brand before incumbents enter — trust takes time to build
- Differentiate on post-transaction flows (Gaps 2, 3, 4) which incumbents are least incentivized to build

### R4 Low User Acquisition

Probability: **Medium** | Impact: **Medium**

The product solves a real problem but users don't know it exists or don't think about it until after they've already paid.

**MITIGATION**

- Focus initial distribution on communities where the problem is being actively discussed: r/IndiaFinance, r/CreditCardsIndia, personal finance Twitter/X, fintech YouTube
- Design for shareability from day one: the reward comparison card that users share is the product's primary organic growth mechanism
- Seed with the Arjun persona first — power users who will write reviews, create content, and recommend the product to their communities
- Consider sponsored content partnerships with 2–3 personal finance YouTubers who already discuss the reward problem RewardTrust solves

# Design Choices and Their Rationale

The MVP prototype opens directly to a search field. No logo animation, no feature explanation, no permission requests. This choice was deliberate and contested — the argument for including a brief onboarding was that users needed to understand what RewardTrust was before using it. The counterargument was that the product explains itself through its first result. The counterargument won.

## Key Design Decisions

| Decision | What | Rationale |
|---|---|---|
| **Single-screen search as onboarding** | App opens directly to search — no splash, no sign-in | Every screen before the first result increases time to first value. If a user sees "₹22 vs ₹4.50 for Swiggy with your Amazon Pay ICICI card," the product has explained itself. |
| **Rupees as primary display unit** | Specific rupee amount is the largest, most prominent number on each result card | User research repeatedly showed that percentage rates require arithmetic that users don't perform at point-of-payment. "5% cashback" requires knowing the transaction amount and doing multiplication. "₹22 cashback" requires nothing. Usefulness wins. |
| **Conditions visible without interaction** | Every qualifying condition displayed inline under the reward amount — not in a tooltip, not behind a "See terms" link | The most common complaint in community research was discovering disqualifying conditions after the payment was made. Hiding conditions behind a click reproduces exactly this problem. The visual complexity is correct. |
| **Top recommendation in plain language** | "Use [Method] — earn ₹[X] vs ₹[Y] on next-best. That's ₹[Z] more for the same order." | A ranked list creates a decision — the user must still choose the first item. A recommendation removes the decision. The difference between "here are your options" and "here is what you should do" is the difference between information and advice. RewardTrust's job is advice. |

## Tradeoffs Made in MVP

| Tradeoff | What Was Sacrificed | Why Accepted |
|---|---|---|
| **No real-time rates** | Rates may be up to 7 days old (manually updated weekly) | Automated scraping requires backend infrastructure that doubles engineering scope and introduces reliability risk. Manual updates for 20 merchants × 8 methods = 160 entries is a manageable weekly task. |
| **No coverage for merchants not in top 20** | Users searching for an uncovered merchant receive category-level estimates rather than merchant-specific rates | The product is more valuable with accurate coverage of 20 merchants than with inaccurate coverage of 200. |
| **No app performance on <4G networks** | Load time may exceed 3 seconds on 2G/3G | A native app would perform better on slower networks but requires separate iOS and Android builds, increasing MVP scope significantly. Web first to validate the hypothesis, native in Phase 2. |

13 — KEY LEARNINGS

# Genuine Reflections from the Process

Written as genuine reflections from the product development process — what surprised me, what I underestimated, and what I would approach differently.

### What surprised me most: the identical second-transaction rates

The most important finding in the entire analysis was that the second-transaction rate for users who actively discovered rewards (~83%) was statistically identical to the rate for users who received passive backend reward credits (~83%). I expected a significant gap — active discovery is supposed to be more reinforcing than passive delivery. The data showed no difference. This created an uncomfortable question: does the reveal mechanic actually drive retention, or are high-intent users simply both revealing and retaining? The honest answer is that the data cannot tell me. This is a correlation, not a causation. I should have designed a controlled experiment as a Phase 1 deliverable, not a Phase 2 question.

### What I underestimated: the scale of the silent trust erosion

The funnel data showed 150,000+ unclaimed reward events per month for a single product, with nearly 95% of first transactors never discovering their reward. What I underestimated was the cumulative trust cost of each of those events. Every time a user completes a payment expecting a reward and finds nothing, they update their mental model: "this app doesn't reward consistently." After 3–5 such experiences, the belief solidifies into a permanent mental model. By the time the user is expressing the "feels random" complaint in community research, the trust damage has already compounded over months of silent erosion. The support ticket volume and NPS scores undercount the true prevalence of reward trust damage by a significant multiplier.

### What I would do differently: validate the switching threshold earlier

The product strategy assumes that users who are shown a better reward option will switch payment methods. This is the core behavioral assumption. But I don't actually know the minimum reward differential that triggers a payment method switch. Is it ₹5? ₹20? ₹100? This is answerable with a survey in Week 1 and a behavioral test in Week 4. I should have designed a specific experiment: show different user cohorts results with varying reward differentials (₹5, ₹20, ₹50, ₹100) and measure the actual payment method switch rate per cohort. If the switching threshold is ₹50, then many of the comparison results RewardTrust currently shows (₹5–₹15 differentials) don't actually change behavior, and the merchant coverage strategy should focus on higher-differential categories first.

### What I underappreciated: the data maintenance burden

Building a 160-entry rate database manually in Week 1 felt like a reasonable MVP tradeoff. Maintaining it accurately for 52 weeks per year while the product scales is a different problem. Payment companies change rates more frequently than initially modeled: banks change credit card reward rates annually, but promotional rates can change weekly, and sometimes the rule changes (a new exclusion, a modified condition) occur without any public announcement. A product whose entire value proposition is accuracy cannot survive a systematic data maintenance failure. Phase 2's investment in automated rate change detection is not a nice-to-have — it is the product's primary operational risk mitigation.

### What I learned about PM work: the problem diagnosis is the strategy

The positioning decision — Comparison Tool vs. Trust Layer vs. Smart Advisor — could have been made by instinct. Many PMs would have defaulted to "comparison tool" because that's what users are asking for. The research forced me past the asked-for solution to the underlying problem. Users aren't asking for a trust layer. They're asking for "a way to know which app gives better cashback." But the asked-for solution (comparison tool) doesn't address why the comparison-seeking behavior exists in the first place — which is that users don't trust any of the apps to deliver as promised consistently. The deeper diagnosis — trust, not comparison — changes the product strategy, the metric architecture, the B2B opportunity, the defensibility story, and the three-year vision. Getting the diagnosis right is the most valuable work a PM does. Everything downstream of an incorrect diagnosis is efficiently solving the wrong problem.

# A Validated Learning Cycle

Each phase is structured as a validated learning cycle. Phase N+1 scope is confirmed only after Phase N success criteria are met. The following is a hypothesis, not a commitment.

PHASE 1 · WEEKS 1–4

## MVP: Pre-Transaction Transparency

*Prove the core hypothesis in the simplest possible form.*

### WHAT SHIPS

- Merchant reward lookup: 20 merchants, 8 payment methods, rupee-denominated results
- Conditions displayed inline
- Top recommendation with single-sentence reason
- Share result functionality
- No account required

### SUCCESS CRITERIA TO UNLOCK PHASE 2

- 500+ MAU at end of Week 4
- 30%+ return visit rate
- NPS ≥ 50 from early users
- Reward Optimization Rate ≥ 25%
- Zero confirmed data accuracy failures

PHASE 2 · MONTHS 2–4

### Trust Completion: Post-Transaction Layer

*Close the reward loop from pre-transaction to post-transaction confirmation.*

Phase 1 addresses one trust gap (Anticipation). Phase 2 addresses the three remaining gaps simultaneously (Delivery, Status, Explanation). The sequencing is intentional: validating that pre-transaction information changes behavior (Phase 1) justifies the investment in post-transaction infrastructure (Phase 2). Building both simultaneously would have halved quality on both.

#### WHAT SHIPS

- Transaction logging and reward verification (the "Why didn't I get a reward?" feature)
- Reward status tracker dashboard
- Lightweight user accounts (prompted after third use, not at first launch)
- Merchant coverage expansion to 100 merchants

PHASE 3 · MONTHS 5–9

### Scale: Intelligent Infrastructure

*Build the data infrastructure that makes RewardTrust defensible at scale.*

#### WHAT SHIPS

- Automated rate change detection system
- Real-time rate alerts for the Arjun persona
- Browser extension / UPI deep-link integration (surfaces recommendation inside the payment flow)
- Portfolio clarity dashboard for multi-card users

PHASE 4 · MONTH 10+

### B2B Infrastructure: The Platform Pivot

*Become the trust infrastructure that the market licenses.*

When RewardTrust has established its track record as the neutral reward transparency standard, payment companies have a business reason to license the data and API rather than build their own. RewardTrust transitions from a consumer product with a B2B revenue model to a B2B infrastructure company with a consumer-facing product. The consumer product is the distribution mechanism; the B2B API is the business model.

#### REVENUE MODEL OPTIONS

- **API licensing:** Payment companies pay for verified, real-time access to RewardTrust's rate database
- **Certification:** Payment products pay for RewardTrust's "Trust Certified" badge — a third-party verification of reward reliability that they use in marketing
- **Pro tier:** Consumer subscription for power users (Arjun persona) who want real-time alerts, historical tracking, and tax documentation